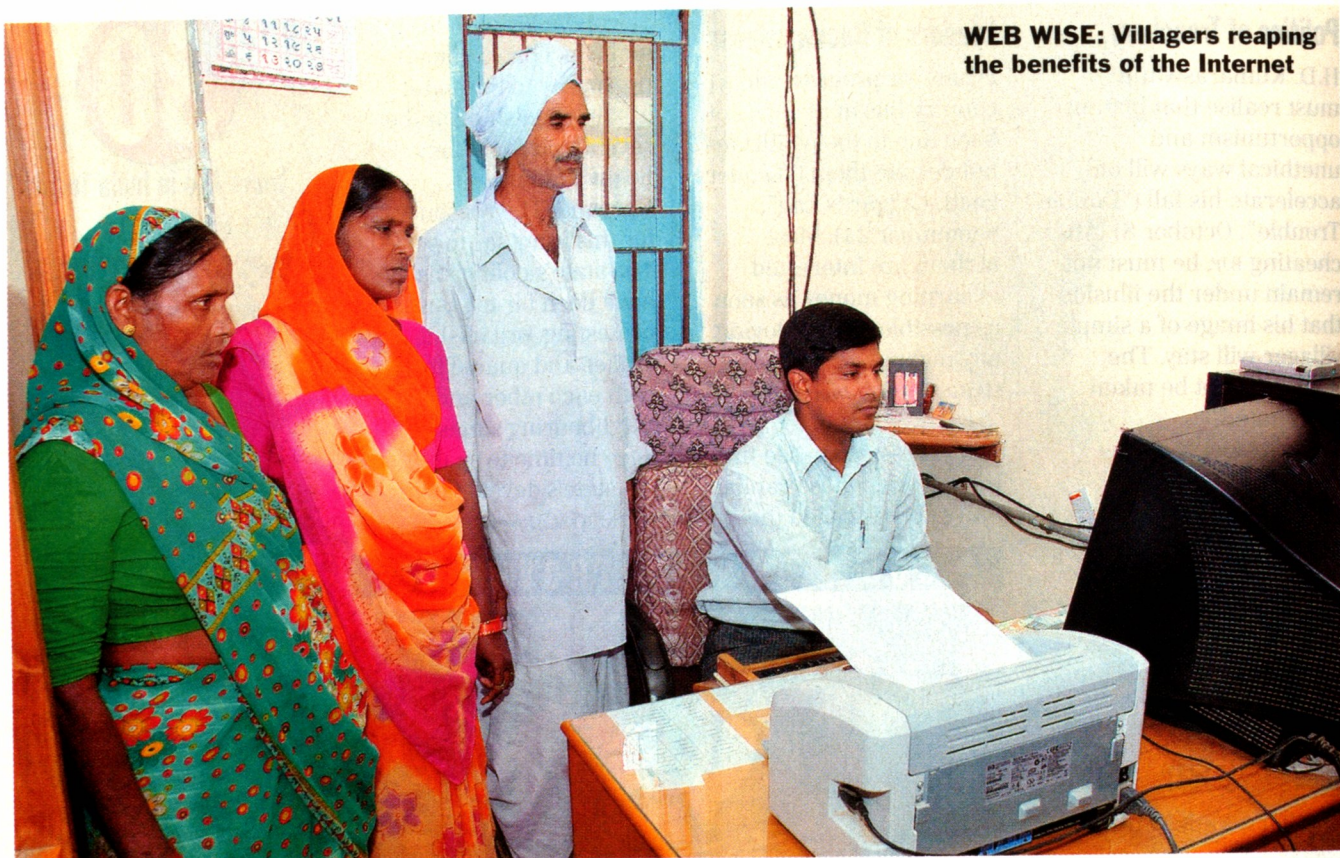




WEB WISE: Villagers reaping the benefits of the Internet

World Wide Villages

A broadband revolution brings the power of instant connectivity to 13,693 gram panchayats

■ **By Uday Mahurkar**

A decade ago, if you had told a villager in a remote part of Gujarat that he could pay his electricity bills with a computer plugged into the vast digital tracts of the Internet, he would have laughed, or perhaps looked at you incredulously. Enter the age of communication, where each of the 13,693 village panchayats in the state is connected to the World Wide Web at the speed of 256 kilobits per second, thanks to the state Government's IT Mission programme. Says Jetha Bariya, sarpanch of Mota Surela village in Panchmahal district, "Internet access gives us a feeling of being one with the rest of the state."

It took two years and Rs 150 crore for the E-Gram Vishwa-Gram Society—a special purpose vehicle set up by the Gujarat Government—to install computers, tie up with Internet service providers and train villagers, particularly patwaris and sarpanches. Infrastructure Leasing & Financial Services Ltd (IL&FS) was appointed lead manager of the project. Says Varesh Sinha, state panchayat secretary, who, along with IAS officers Vipul Mitra and Rajgopal, played a key role in implementing the programme, "Broadband connectivity will change the lives of villagers forever." The computerisa-



tion was made possible by another scheme, Jyotigram, under which all villages get 24-hour, three-phase domestic power supply.

Broadband connectivity has made it possible for villagers to connect online with taluk, district and state headquarters through video conferencing. Now they can apply for birth and death certificates and book train tickets

without having to trudge miles. Not only has the Internet helped bridge distances, it has also flung open the floodgates of information. Tele-education, tele-medicine and online agricultural advice are only some of the possibilities that will make life much easier for the villagers. The facility has also enabled a host of other services, making administration more efficient. The web-based, double-entry accounting system, for example, has made book-keeping transparent.

Though India has seen much technological progress in the last decade, very few villages have broadband connections. Says Hari Shankaran, CMD, IL&FS: "The implications of this development are truly extraordinary. Every village will now have access to a globalised economy." According to IAS officer Aruna Soundararajan, who is also associated with IL&FS, the Union Government is looking forward to replicating this effort in other states. India lives in its villages. It's time the world did too.